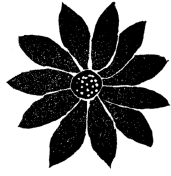


Iler-CaraDonna Lab Meeting Tips On Academic Writing



This is a collection of tips, tricks, and suggestions for academic writing that I have compiled as a participant in lab meetings of the Iler-CaraDonna ecology labs over the last three years. These are not meant to be prescriptive, but hopefully they provide options and ideas for those looking for them.



- ☐ **ARE COLORS DISTINCT?**
If you are color-coding, are the colors distinct, including for those who are color-blind?

- ☐ **ARE ACRONYMS SPELLED OUT?**
-Are acronyms spelled out the first time they are used?
-Are the acronyms used enough to be worth including?

- ☐ **ACTIVE VOICE!**
Are you using primarily active voice?
- ☐ **IS EVERYTHING PARALLEL?**
-Are your lists grammatically parallel?
-Is anything that you do more than once (change scale, discuss results for multiple species) done in a consistent order?

THINGS TO CHECK:

A note on credit: this project started with me noting strategies and suggestions that I wanted to remember, for my own use, and I usually did not mention who had shared that advice. Often, people were conveying things learned from a previous teacher or colleague. As such I have not credited specific lab members throughout this document. So, I would like to share my gratitude here for the generosity, time, and attention given by all of the lab members over the last three years:

Paul CaraDonna, Amy Iler, Jane Ogilvie, Jacquelyn Fitzgerald, Josh Scholl, Vicki Delira, Justin Bain, Elsa Godfredsen, Amelia Litz, Kyla Krauf, Sam Rosa, Izzy Radelius, Brendan Connolly, Alex Zink, Kathryn Dawdy, Laura Caride, Andrea Groover, Diana Jerome

TIPS AND TRICKS - DRAFTING

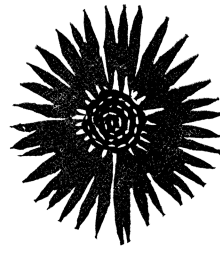
- Pretend to present your introduction (this helps to identify redundancy and clarify the order)
- For the introduction and discussion, try writing the first and last paragraphs first
- Write for people who won't read the whole paper (each section should make general sense alone)



- If you need to cut length in lines/ Pages, work on paragraphs with short last lines first
- Moving the last sentence to the topic sentence is often effective
- If you do large edits, especially if you incorporate feedback from multiple people, write an outline at the end to make sure that the conceptual flow still makes sense
- If you find feedback hard to engage with or overwhelming, I recommend Kirby Connors' article here: 
- That said, change the big things first, because the smaller points might get changed in the process anyway

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

- Follow the question order from the introduction (you can include the questions or answers as numbered headers)
- Can the list of topic sentences tell the story?
- For each paragraph, make the topic sentence the take home point, with details below
- Make the first paragraph of the discussion a synthesis of the take home points



INTRODUCTIONS

- Don't narrow in on your study system too quickly (leave it until the last couple of paragraphs, usually). Instead, explain why the topic is applicable to ecology more broadly
- Refer to knowledge gaps, rather than limited evidence
- Knowledge gaps require you to explain why this specific information is needed. There is limited evidence for almost everything; that alone is not a strong basis for your work
- Your choice of approach can be a selling point!
- Include specific questions/predictions, and number them
- You can include a "citation teaser" at the end (what does one get from this if they trust the results?)

TIPS AND TRICKS - EDITING